

The Signal Lantern

Three unfinished threads at fictional Wattle Bay.

Noor and the torn map

After school, Noor volunteered to sweep the old signal shed near Wattle Bay. Behind a loose board, she found half a map marked with small blue lanterns. Her grandfather had once told her that the marks showed the route for the annual Lantern Walk, but the paper ended before the harbour steps.

Noor did not know where the route continued. Still, she photographed the map and sent it to Eli, who had been trying to repair the shed's dusty signal lantern for the community display. "It could be a clue," she wrote. "Not proof - just a clue."

Known: Noor has found part of a map. **Unknown:** whether it shows a safe, usable walking route.

Eli and the quiet light

Eli had cleaned the lantern's cracked glass and replaced a loose wire with help from his aunt. When he pressed the switch, the light glowed for a moment, then flickered. He wanted to show the caretaker, Mrs Vale, but he was worried that a repair made at home might not be enough for an event.

He made a list of what the lantern still needed: a proper safety check, a new mounting bracket and someone from the council to inspect it. He had not shown the lantern to anyone yet.

Known: Eli has made a partial repair and a list.
Unknown: whether the lantern will pass inspection.

Trace the strands

- N** Noor: a clue, map, possible route
- E** Eli: repair, uncertainty, inspection
- V** Mrs Vale: decision, path, community walk

Mark it

E = direct evidence

I = what it may mean

P = possible future event

Do not mark a future event as confirmed unless the text shows it happened.

A decision still to come

Evidence can point forward without becoming a spoiler.

Mrs Vale's notice

At the harbour noticeboard, Mrs Vale pinned a short message: "This year's Lantern Walk is paused while the old path is checked." She explained that the lower steps had become uneven after heavy rain. The community could not use the usual route until the council had examined it.

When Noor showed her the torn map, Mrs Vale looked carefully at the blue lantern marks. "There may be another way through the gardens," she said. "But a map is not a decision. We need to know where it leads and whether people can use it safely." She asked Noor to bring the other half if she found it.

Eli then told Mrs Vale about the lantern. She thanked him for caring for it but repeated that a safety check would be necessary. By the end of the afternoon, the three people had clues, a possible light and a question. They did not yet have an event.

A careful forecast might connect the map, repair and inspection. It must name what still has to happen.

Reader's challenge

Write one prediction that connects all three strands. Include one condition that keeps your forecast honest.

Prediction chain

Evidence

What is directly stated?

Inference

What could these clues mean together?

Prediction

What may happen next?

Condition

What would need to happen first?

Useful words

could • may • might • perhaps •
if • unless • likely